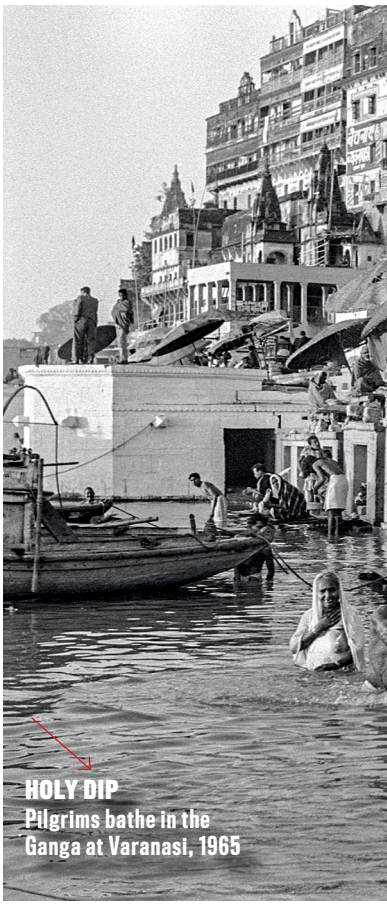
DESTINATION INDIA

A significant contributor to the Indian economy for decades, the tourism sector was hit hard by the Covid pandemic and is now on a slow path to recovery

By Kai Friese

India's tourism sector is etched with the mind-boggling statistics of a slow-starting post-Independence boom and a post-pandemic bust. Once a prestige sector smothered in statist attention, it saw significant liftoff in the early phase of liberalisation, though the State also played a role, hiring marketing firm O&M to sell the global Incredible !ndia brand. By 2019, the industry was contributing some $194 billion—nearly 7 per cent of GDP—and employing 38 million people. The disruptions of Covid were particularly severe for this industry, and recovery has been slow and inevitably led by domestic travel, with many state governments promoting pilgrimage destinations and the PM announcing the Dekho Apna Desh campaign.



HOLY DIP
Pilgrims bathe in the Ganga at Varanasi, 1965



10th
India's rank among 185 countries in terms of travel & tourism's total contribution to the GDP in 2019, according to World Travel & Tourism Council (WTTC)

21.5
MILLION
No. of **people in the sector who lost jobs** during the pandemic, said tourism minister G. Kishan Reddy

1.28
MILLION
Foreign tourist arrivals in 1981

10.93
MILLION
Foreign tourist arrivals in 2019

2.74
MILLION
Foreign tourist arrivals in 2020

DOMESTIC TOURIST VISITS FELL FROM **2.3** BILLION IN 2019 TO 610.2 MILLION IN 2020

$30
BILLION
Revenue from inbound tourism in 2019